

ARTERIAL FUNDRAISING, AND EVERYTHING AFTER IT

From a campaign plan to the emails that go out

A discussion paper on building a tool that turns a brief into email sequences, and whether it belongs in Polywiz, on its own, or nowhere

Team discussion · September 2026 · Nothing here is decided

We have the plan, the list, the people and the tools. Not the machine between them.

Julie and Molly write the fundraising plan. Scott records the video. The list is clean and scored. Polywiz can write in our voice. ActiveCampaign can send. **What connects them today is one person, by hand, and that person is the only one who knows how.**

THE QUESTION

Can a tool take a campaign concept and produce the sequences, the timings, the segments and the emails?

THE SECOND QUESTION

If it can, where does it live: inside Polywiz, on its own, or as a kit of parts we already own?

This deck lays out three approaches and ends with the questions we need to answer together. **It recommends one, as an opening position.**

Seven hand-offs, one head

1 · Plan Consultant writes the campaign document	2 · Read Juergen turns it into a send list	3 · Write Each email drafted from scratch	4 · Segment Audiences built in ActiveCampaign	5 · Automate Welcome, thank-you, suppression flows built by hand	6 · Test Test sends, personalisation checked	7 · Schedule Dates set, sends enabled
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Nobody else can preview the sequence before it exists in ActiveCampaign. Nobody else can change a date or a paragraph without asking. **And "remove people who donate from the ask" is rebuilt every time.**

The plan asks for twelve sends in three acts plus four automations, all before October. **Every one of those is a manual build today.**

Twelve sends, three acts, four flows

ACT	WHAT IT DOES	CADENCE THE CONSULTANTS SET
1 · Prove	"Look what we've accomplished." Stories, no ask.	One email a week, soft call to action
2 · Participate	"Become part of what we're building." First hard ask, then story and ask alternating.	One to two a week
3 · Act	"Help make 2027 possible." Giving Tuesday, impact update, year-end deadline.	Two to three a week, daily in the last 48 hours
Always on	Welcome and nurture · abandoned donation · thank-you and receipt · lapsed donor	Triggered, not scheduled

Warm contacts get the full arc, twelve to sixteen emails. The cold bulk is capped at eight to ten. **Anyone who gives leaves the ask stream the same day.** Those three rules are the spec, and they live in a Word document.

Fundraising is one shape of sequence. We need seven.

FUNDRAISING APPEAL

Soft launch, launch, story, progress, match, final day, thank-you.

WELCOME

Four emails over two weeks, or eight over 45 days. No hard ask before the end.

NURTURE / NEWS

"Here is what ArtHouse did this month." One email, right cohort, or a short run.

RE-ENGAGEMENT

"We miss you", what your last gift did, come back.

STEWARDSHIP

Thank-you within 48 hours, then what the gift did.

AMBASSADOR

Recruit past guests to share the impact report, not to give.

PROMOTION

Announce a newsletter, an exhibition, a podcast season. The Intersect, too.

Same engine, different arc. **Whether we build a fundraising tool or an audience tool is a settings question, not an architecture question.**

There are two problems here, not one

PROBLEM ONE · THE ARC

Brief in, sequence out

Understand the brand, read the documents, choose the arc, decide which segments get which variation, write every email, show it all on one timeline, let people edit it.

This is where the value is, and it is the same work whatever sends the email.

PROBLEM TWO · THE DELIVERY

Sequence into ActiveCampaign

Create the emails, aim them at the right segment, set the dates, wire the "stop asking once they give" rule, hand over drafts a person enables.

This is bounded, partly automatable, and partly a hard wall.

Every approach on the following slides keeps these two apart. **The arc side should never know how the email will be sent.**

PART ONE

What the arc side has to know

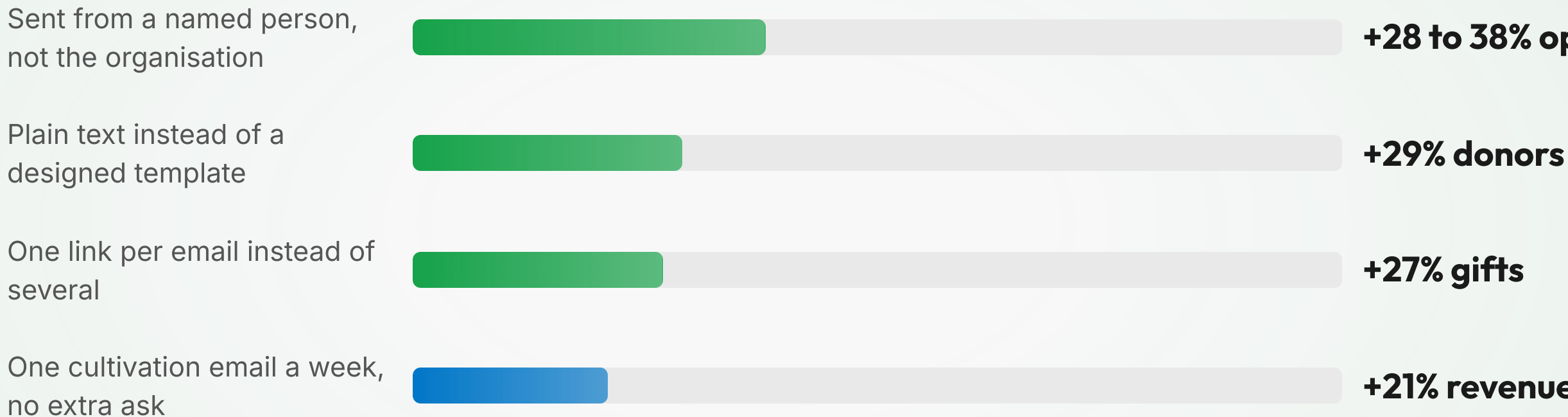
The best-practice foundations a generator must carry, so it proposes something a fundraiser would recognise.

Every good sequence follows a published pattern

SEQUENCE	EMAILS · SPAN	WHAT EACH ONE DOES
Welcome	4 · 14 days, or 8 · 45 days	Person introduces themselves and asks for a reply · what we offer · a story · a resource · only the last one asks
Appeal	7 to 10 · 3 to 6 weeks	Soft launch to insiders · launch · one story · progress bar · match if there is one · final day morning, midday, evening · thank-you
New donor	3 · one a week	Gratitude and a story, no ask · what your gift did · invitation to give monthly
Lapsed	2 · two weeks apart	What your last gift did, reply to me · an appeal tied to outcomes
Ambassador	4 · first week	Thanks and a share nudge · milestone · make your own first gift · it is hard, here is help

Sources: NextAfter, Bloomerang, GivingTuesday toolkit, Funraise. **The tool proposes the shape; the operator edits it. The model never invents structure.**

The evidence points away from "make it beautiful"



All from NextAfter's published experiments. **A generator that defaults to a person's name, plain text and one link is encoding the evidence, not a taste.** The consultants' plan already says the same thing.

One arc, four things that change per segment

THE STORY HOOK

A past podcast guest hears their own episode named in sentence one. A prior donor hears what their gift did. A stranger hears the problem and the proof.

THE ASK

Anchored to giving history for donors. A declared default for everyone else. Never a number the model chose.

THE CALL TO ACTION

Give · give again · come back · share this · reply to me. Ambassadors are asked to share, not to give.

THE SENDER

Always a person. Scott for the list. The host who knows them for guests. Elise for Artsville.

What stays shared: the arc, the dates, the story beats. **Segmented sends open 14% more and click twice as often as blasts**, across eleven thousand campaigns Mailchimp measured.

The timeline reads as one campaign with four voices, not four campaigns.

The audiences exist. Most have never been written to as themselves.

AUDIENCE	SIZE	WHAT IS DIFFERENT ABOUT THE MESSAGE
Past podcast guests	258, 81 matched so far	We interviewed you. Help us share the impact report.
Grant winners	36 across five cycles	You were funded. Here is what that fund does next.
Artists on the list	2,967	Cheerleaders, not critics. Peer to peer.
Artsville readers	1,136, through Ghost	Craft and place. Sent by Elise, not from ActiveCampaign.
Prior donors	134 on the donor lists	Thank first. Then the monthly invitation.

Plus the 5,648 on the fundraising list who get the capped consumer arc. **Almost nobody knows Arterial by name.** They know Not Real Art or Artsville, so which brand a person came through is the first thing the tool must know.

Three failures the tool must be built around

IT DID THE MATHS

Handed a date, the model wrote "it's been over a year since you exhibited with us" to a real person. It had been five weeks. **Now every interval is computed in code and handed over as finished words.**

A CLICK BECAME A RELATIONSHIP

"Clicked the Not Real Art home page" turned into "you were featured on Not Real Art". Plausible, specific and false. **A click is never described as participation.**

NUMBERS WITHOUT A SOURCE

A fabricated statistic in a funder report damages credibility permanently. **Every number, name and outcome in a draft must trace to an uploaded document or a contact field, or it is flagged.**

These three are already enforced in the outreach drafting workflow we run today. **They come with us, along with "a human signs every donor-facing message".**

PART TWO

What ActiveCampaign lets a machine build

Checked against the vendor's own API documentation this week, and against what we have already probed in our account.

Broadcasts: fully buildable. Automations: not by any API.

WHAT THE TOOL WOULD NEED TO CREATE	BY API	NOTES
A one-off email in draft , with HTML, list, segment and a send date	Yes	One call. Nothing sends until a person enables it.
The email content, subject, sender, preheader	Yes	Lands as custom HTML; the drag-and-drop designer will not show it.
A test send to the operator	Yes	Checks personalisation before anyone else sees it.
A saved segment	Partly	Only shapes the segment builder makes are guaranteed. Build one by hand, copy it.
An automation : trigger, wait, send, goal, exit	No	No create, edit, copy, share or import call in either API version.

The tools ActiveCampaign ships for AI assistants have the same shape: read, tag, enrol, edit a message. **Nothing creates an automation, and nothing sends.**

Two kinds of sequence, and only one needs an automation

CALENDAR SEQUENCES

Everyone gets email four on the same day

The fundraising arc. Giving Tuesday. Year end. A news email about ArtHouse. A newsletter promotion.

These are scheduled broadcasts aimed at a segment. Fully buildable by API today, in draft, per segment, with dates.

TRIGGERED SEQUENCES

Something happens to one person

Someone joins the list. Someone gives. Someone abandons a donation. Someone goes quiet for a year.

These are automations. Built once, by hand or by ActiveCampaign's own AI, then reused for years.

The plan's twelve sends are all calendar sequences. The four always-on flows are triggered. **The repeated work is automatable; the one-time work is the part that is not.**

"Stop asking once they give" does not need a new automation

FOR CALENDAR SENDS

The segment decides at send time

Each broadcast is aimed at a segment whose conditions include "does not have the tag Donated 2026". Whoever gave on Tuesday is not in Thursday's audience. No flow, no exit step, nothing to rebuild per campaign.

FOR TRIGGERED FLOWS

One goal step, built once

A goal early in each welcome or nurture flow watches for that tag and ends the automation. Or one central "donation received" flow ends every ask flow and starts the thank-you.

Both depend on the same thing: **every donation path applies the tag**. Donately reaches ActiveCampaign through Zapier today; the tag has to be in that mapping, and the donor lists holding 11 and 1 members say it is not yet.

One tag, applied reliably, is the entire suppression system. **That is a data job, not a tool job, and it is on the critical path either way.**

ActiveCampaign's own AI will draft a whole automation from a paragraph

Since October 2025, on every plan: paste "generate a four-email welcome sequence for new artist subscribers" into the sidebar and the **Automations agent** drafts the triggers, the waits and the email copy into the builder for review. There is also an AI campaign builder for single emails and a brand kit that reads colours and fonts off a URL.

WHAT IT IS GOOD AT

The skeleton. A person who has never opened the automation builder gets a reviewable flow in a minute.

WHAT IT IS NOT

Our voice, our facts, our segments, our guardrails. No API, so nothing can drive it or read what it made except a person.

So the workable division is: **our tool writes the brief and the emails; a person pastes the brief into their agent to get the flow; our tool then replaces the generated copy with ours.** Not a hack. The only route to a generated automation that exists.

Nobody sells this shape

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	PUSHES A SEQUENCE INTO ACTIVECAMPAIGN?
Klaviyo Flows AI	Description in, full flow out. The closest analogue.	No. Inside Klaviyo only.
Jasper email sequence	Multi-step copy from a brief, any platform.	Paste only. No arc logic, no nonprofit rules.
Dataro	AI appeals and journeys from donor data. New ActiveCampaign link in July.	Reads from it. Does not write drafts into it.
Raisely, Funraise, Keela, Bloomerang, Bonterra	Journeys inside their own sending tools.	No. Each is its own email system.
HubSpot, Mailchimp assistants	Single emails, generic copy.	No.

Everything that builds sequences builds them inside its own sender. **Nothing takes a brief plus uploaded documents, writes per-segment sequences on a timeline, and drafts them into ActiveCampaign.** The niche is real, and it is small.

PART THREE

What we already own, and what nobody has built

An inventory across Polywiz, the Intersect curator, Auctor and this campaign's own tooling.

Most of the arc side already exists somewhere

CAPABILITY	WHERE IT LIVES	STATE
Brand voice , eight tone dimensions, compiled prompt	Polywiz	Mature. The Intersect curator copies the same model.
Document upload and interpretation	Polywiz	Mature. A PDF is read and assessed on arrival.
Campaign arc : awareness, amplification, invitation, ask	Polywiz	Works, but computed from a post's position. Nothing is stored.
Retell it in your own voice so it stops sounding generated	Auctor	Live. Called by Polywiz and the curator.
Preview, edit, regenerate, accept a generated piece	Polywiz, curator	Mature screens.
ActiveCampaign client , segments, engagement, matching	This campaign's scripts	Read paths proven live. One careful writer.
Draft one email with guardrails	n8n workflow	Live since 3 September.

Six of seven were built for something else. **None of them knows what a sequence is.**

Six things that do not exist in any of our repositories

1

A stored sequence

Emails in order, each with a stage, a day offset, a segment, a subject and a body. Polywiz keeps nothing.

2

Email composition

No email rendering anywhere except password resets.

3

ActiveCampaign link

None in Polywiz or the curator. Only this campaign's scripts talk to it.

4

Video intake

Scott's recorded update has no way in. Only pasted text does.

5

A per-brand gate

Polywiz has switches for images and link-in-bio. No general "show this tab for this brand".

6

A sequence timeline

The website has the look, Polywiz has a track for posts. Neither shows segments as rows.

Gap one is the heart of it. Every approach on the next slides has to build it; they differ in where it lives.

PART FOUR

Three ways to build it

A tab in Polywiz, a tool of its own, or a kit of parts. Then a recommendation.

A gated "Sequences" tab inside Polywiz

WHAT IT REUSES

Brand voice, document intake, the arc, Auctor, the sanitiser, the preview-and-edit screens, logins the team already has, the credit meter.

WHAT IT ADDS

A sequence table, email rendering, the timeline view, a per-brand switch, and an ActiveCampaign connection with the account's key held per brand.

THE GATE

One boolean on the brand plus one sidebar entry. The switch pattern exists; the tab is invisible for brands that do not fundraise.

FOR IT

Teammates get a real screen without a new login. The brand knows itself. Shortest path to "Scott can preview and tweak".

AGAINST IT

Polywiz becomes an email tool for one customer. Three separate generation routes each need the new block. Airtable is the store. Clutter risk is real and the reason the gate exists.

Effort: medium. **Most of the new code is the sequence model and the ActiveCampaign push, which every approach needs anyway.**

A tool of its own, built for sequences

WHAT IT IS

A small app whose whole screen is the timeline: segments as rows, weeks as columns, every email a card you open, edit, regenerate and approve. Brief and documents on the left, ActiveCampaign push on the right.

WHAT IT BORROWS

The voice model copied in, the way the curator did. The arc rules. Auctor over HTTP. This campaign's ActiveCampaign client as its delivery layer.

FOR IT

Nothing to clutter. Its data model is exactly the sequence. Could serve the Intersect and Artsville without asking Polywiz's permission. Cleanest home for the ActiveCampaign key.

AGAINST IT

A second copy of the brand configuration that drifts. Another app to host, log into, and keep alive. Slowest path to a first usable screen. The auctor-platform and email-helper repos both stalled at exactly this gate.

Effort: high. **Right answer if Polywiz's tenancy or Airtable turns out to be the wrong fit; wrong answer to start with, because we would learn that from A or C first.**

No new app. A kit: a sequence file, a review page, and a push script

Brief + material	Generate	Review page	Push	Flows
Plan, impact report, blog post, transcript of Scott's video	One sequence file: arc, segments, dates, every email with its sources	One offline page with the timeline, like the ambassador page Julie and Scott use. Edit, export	Drafts every calendar email into ActiveCampaign per segment, test-sends to the operator	A build sheet for the four automations, pasted into the vendor's agent, read back to check

FOR IT

Weeks, not months. Every piece is a tool the future chatbot calls. Proves the sequence model before anything wraps it. Runs this quarter's campaign not by hand.

AGAINST IT

Teammates edit in a page, not an app. Brand voice is fetched from Polywiz, not shared. Generation starts from a terminal until the chatbot exists.

Effort: low to medium. **C is not a lesser A. It is the engine A would need, built first and on its own.**

The same six questions asked of each

	A · POLYWIZ TAB	B · OWN TOOL	C · KIT
Teammates preview and edit without Juergen	Yes, in an app they use	Yes, in a new app	Yes, in an offline page
Reuses brand voice and document intake	Directly	Copied	Fetches
Clutters Polywiz for brands that do not need it	Gated, some risk	None	None
Time to first real sequence in ActiveCampaign	Months	Months	Weeks
Feeds the "chatbot that understands the project"	Indirectly	Indirectly	Directly, tool by tool
Delivery into ActiveCampaign	Identical. Broadcasts by API in draft; automations built once through the vendor's agent.		

The delivery row is the tell. **The approaches differ only in where the arc side lives and who can touch it.**

Build C now. Let it earn A.

NOW · THIS QUARTER

The kit

Sequence file, generator, review page with a timeline, draft push for calendar sends, build sheet for the four flows. Used on the real fall campaign, with the consultants' plan as the brief.

THEN · IF IT HOLDS

Wrap it in Polywiz

The sequence file becomes a table. The review page becomes a tab, gated per brand. Brand voice and document intake stop being fetched and start being shared.

ONLY IF

Its own tool

If the Polywiz fit fails on evidence: tenancy, Airtable, or a second brand that needs it and has no Polywiz account.

Why this order: the arc side is the reusable value and it is unproven. **Proving it on one real campaign, in the cheapest wrapper, is what tells us whether the tab is worth building.** The same rule this project already applies to the chatbot.

This is a position to argue with, not a decision. **The questions at the end are what would change it.**

PART FIVE

What the thing would look like

The intake, the timeline, the drill-down, and who does what.

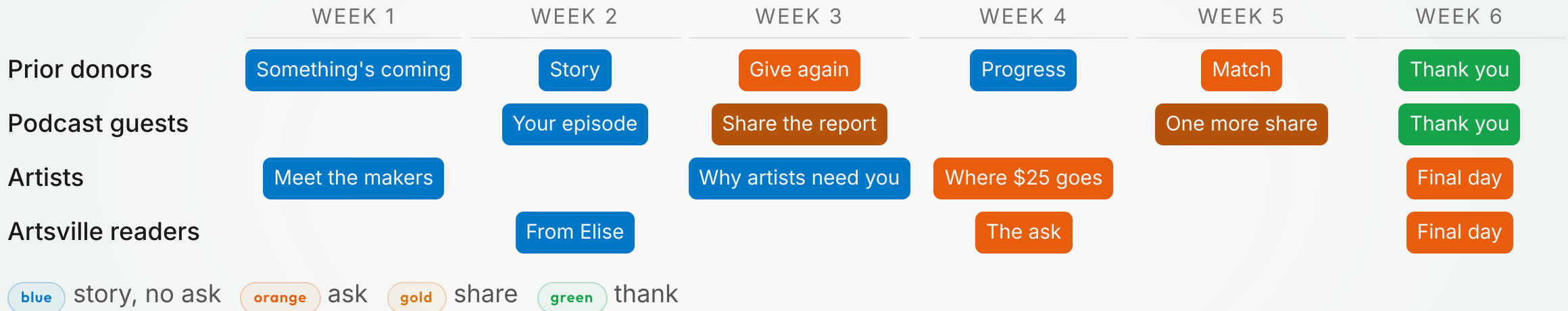
Six questions, then generate

1 · Which brand Not Real Art, Artsville, Arterial, the Intersect. Voice and sender follow.	2 · Which shape Appeal, welcome, news, re- engagement, stewardship, ambassador, promotion.	3 · The brief What should this achieve, by when, with what ask.	4 · The material Plan, impact report, blog post, video transcript. Each fact keeps its source.	5 · Who gets it Segments picked from the account, each with its story hook and sender.	6 · The limits Sends per week, quiet days, the frequency cap for cold contacts.
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Steps one, two and four already exist in Polywiz as a brand picker, a campaign type, and a document drop zone. **Step five is the new one, and it reads the segments we have already built.**

A video is a transcript with a source id. **Nothing in the output may say something the material does not.**

One campaign, four voices, six weeks, one screen



Click any card and you get its intention, its story beat, subject, sender, call to action, the sources it drew on, and the text. **Move a card and every date after it shifts.** This is the screen Scott and Julie would work from.

The tool proposes. People decide. Nothing sends itself.

WHO	DOES	DOES NOT
Julie, Molly	Write the plan and the messaging direction. The plan is the brief.	Operate ActiveCampaign.
The tool	Proposes the arc, writes every email from the material, shows the timeline, drafts into ActiveCampaign, flags anything it cannot source.	Choose an ask amount. Invent a story. Send.
Scott, Elise	Edit, retell in their own voice through Auctor, approve. Their name is on it.	Build segments or flows.
Juergen, then anyone	Enable the drafts, paste the build sheet, apply the donor tag mapping.	Write emails from scratch.

The last row is the point. **Enabling a draft is a ten-minute job anyone can be shown. Building the sequence from a Word document is not.**

What lands in ActiveCampaign, and how

BY THE SCRIPT

Up to 12 sends × 4 segments, as drafts

Each with its own copy, aimed at a segment cloned from one built by hand, dated, test-sent. A person enables them.

BY A PERSON, ONCE

Four automations

Welcome, abandoned donation, thank-you, lapsed. Brief pasted into the vendor's agent, our copy dropped in, the donor goal added.

BY THE DATA JOB

One tag on every donation

Donately's Zapier mapping applies "Donated 2026". Every segment and goal keys on it.

Three things need one live probe each first: the send date at creation, replacing copy inside an automation email, and conditional blocks in custom HTML. **Each is a ten-minute test against a throwaway.**

Five requests a second for the whole account, shared with the artwork intake. **Drafting 48 emails takes about a minute.**

Six risks, and which ones the design already answers

RISK	ANSWER
The model invents a fact, a number or a person	Every claim carries a source id or a flag. No composite stories. Human signs every message.
Faster writing means more sending	Frequency caps are part of the sequence file, not advice. Cold contacts stop at ten. Nobody goes three weeks silent either.
It reads as a computer wrote it	Voice compiled per brand, no em dashes at the boundary, Auctor for the emails that matter most.
The tool second-guesses the consultants	The plan is the brief. The tool executes it and shows the arc; it does not propose a different one unasked.
Open rates mislead us again	Four in ten opens are Apple Mail. Scoring reads clicks and real opens; Artsville is read through Ghost.
The dates in the plan get treated as a calendar	The sequence keeps the order and the gaps; the start date is a single field.

General engine, fundraising first

WHY GENERAL

The seven shapes share everything but the arc. A news email about ArtHouse, a welcome for new Intersect readers and a year-end appeal all need a brand, material, segments, a timeline and a draft in the sender. Building the fundraising shape alone would still build all of that.

WHY FUNDRAISING FIRST

It is the shape with a real plan, a real deadline and a consultant's document to test the intake against. It also carries the hardest rule, "stop asking once they give", so if the engine handles it the others are easy.

The delineation that does hold: **the tool ends at a draft in the sending system.** It never sends, never scores donors, never replaces Julie's book of 66 prospects. Major gifts stay a human job.

Name it for what it does, not for fundraising. **"Sequences" is honest; "fundraising tool" would be narrower than the thing.**

Eight decisions that need only one person

- Is the consultants' plan the brief, verbatim, for the first run?
- Which four segments does the first run target, and is the podcast guest list one of them?
- Does Donately's Zapier mapping apply a donor tag today, and if not, who owns adding it?
- Do we build the sequence on the Not Real Art brand in Polywiz, or on an Arterial brand that does not exist there yet?
- Is Scott willing to retell the ask emails through Auctor, or only to edit text?
- Where does the ActiveCampaign key live for the push: this repository, n8n, or Polywiz?
- Plain-text emails by default, with the designed template only on request?
- Is "weeks, on the real fall campaign" the right test, or do we want a dry run on a news email first?

Answered one at a time and written down, these turn the recommendation into a first sprint. **None of them needs the whole team.**

Seven things to discuss that may not get an answer today

- Who edits and approves an email before it is enabled, and does that person's name go on the sender line?
- How much do Julie and Molly want the tool to propose, versus execute exactly what the plan says?
- Which of us should be able to enable a send in ActiveCampaign, so it stops being one person?
- Should past podcast guests be asked to give at all, or only to share?
- Is the Artsville audience part of this, given it is emailed by Elise through Ghost and not from ActiveCampaign?
- What does the tool owe the major-gift track: nothing, or a stewardship sequence for the 66?
- If the kit works, is a Polywiz tab worth its clutter, or does this stay a tool for us?

Each of these changes the design in a different direction. **They are the reason this is a discussion paper and not a plan.**

WHERE THIS LEAVES US

Build the arc first, and build it small.

A sequence file, a timeline page anyone can edit, and a script that drafts into ActiveCampaign. Used once on the real campaign. Then we know whether it deserves a home in Polywiz.

The full discussion paper, with sources, sits beside this deck.